

HORSES GO THROUGH THEIR
PACES AT THE AHMEDABAD SHOW



Photographs by SHAILESH RAVAL/www.indiatodayimages.com

Horse SENSE

Gujarat leads the way in reviving and saving vanishing local horse breeds

By Uday Mahurkar

One unforgettable moment during the Republic Day parade in Delhi is the sight of the President driving up Rajpath, accompanied by the members of the President's Bodyguard on their majestic steeds. It's ironic as well. The Presidential limo represents the reason that horses became an endangered species: the arrival of the automobile, courtesy Henry Ford. Horses were meant for courses, race courses. While thoroughbreds survived, the big question mark in recent years was over the future of indigenous breeds. So, the huge turnout and participation recently at the annual Gujarat horse show of Kathiawadi and Marwadi breeds at Ahmedabad came as a major surprise. Over 300 horses and their owners attended the show organised jointly by the Gujarat Government and the Equestrian Association of Gujarat (EAS).

The horse owners came from diverse sections of the society—tradi-

tional Kathiawadi owners from Saurashtra along with members of many business families in Ahmedabad and Vadodara who have taken up horse-riding and breeding either as a hobby or a profession.

One reason for the success of the show was the fact that the EAS had added Rs 10 lakh worth of prizes to the Rs 1 lakh that the Government extends to such shows.

“It's not just owning, the new generation takes pleasure in riding horses too.”

GAJENDRAPAL SINGH POSANA,
Expert on horse breeds



The revival of local breeds was a dream till a few years ago. Now it seems reality.

MAHESH PATEL, President, EAS



As Mahesh Patel, president of EAS and a leading Marwadi and Kathiawadi horse breeder, puts it: “The revival of local breeds was only a dream till a few years ago. Now it seems reality.” The figures tell the story of the revival. In the past five years, the number of locally-bred horses has grown from 9,000 to 13,000, of which 55 per cent are of Kathiawadi origin and the rest Marwadi. This figure was static at between 7,000 and 8,000 a decade ago. Of the total breeders in the state, there are over 30 who own more than 10 horses and over 200 who own more than five. Says Ghanshyamdasji Maharaj, the mahant of the famous Bhuvaneshwari Pith of Gondal in Saurashtra and the man who has played a major role in encouraging interest in the two breeds: “Today, traders are coming from as far away as Uttar Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh and Maharashtra to buy our Kathiawadi and Marwadi stallions to revive their local breeds. The results in Maharashtra have been exceptionally good.”